Technical Instructions

Research Accommodation

Feature Story

Magazine Layout

Infographic

Data Report

Text Revision and Analysis

Contract Example

FEATURE STORY

PROFESSIONAL AND TECHNICAL WRITING

PROJECT TITLE

The Hidden Gems of Pittsburgh's Hills

DESCRIPTION

This feature piece required me to conduct an interview and profile either a place or person. I chose to base my story on the history of a church in Pittsburgh that houses 5,000 relics of the Catholic Faith. I spoke to Chapel Chairperson Carole Brueckner to feature her perspective and relationship to the church.

AUDIENCE

General Audience

Pittsburgh Residents

SKILLS DEVELOPED

- Interviewed a subject to create a profile of them
- Developed a narrative catered to my audience
- Portrayed the speaker's words and their story honestly and fairly

APPLICATIONS USED

- Microsoft Word
- Adobe InDesign
- Audacity
- VLC Media Player

THE HIDDEN GEMS OF PITTSBURGH'S HILLS

Venture into St. Anthony's chapel in the Troy Hill neighborhood of Pittsburgh, and you'll be surrounded, floor to ceiling, by brass, gold, jewels, and bones.

Upon entering, patrons have a difficult time deciding where to look first. Some draw close to the sides of the chapel, where each of the twelve stations of the cross are acted out by life sized, hand-carved wooden statues. Some gaze upwards to stained glass windows depicting saints in vibrant glory. Others move forward, towards an array of white candles that separates the larger nave of the church to the confined pews in front of the altar. There, locked away behind glass, rest thousands of precious pieces of history.

St. Anthony's contains over 5,000 relics of the Catholic Faith. The church overlooks the city of Pittsburgh, sitting atop a neighborhood known as Troy Hill. Anyone passing by the church would find it hard to fathom that inside lies the biggest repository of Catholic relics outside of the Vatican. Its beige stone walls may stand out from the neighboring town homes, but many unfamiliar with its hidden gems would assume it's just another chapel. As it is first and foremost a place of worship for its longtime parish members, this is just a part of the little chapel's charm.

When asked how long chapel chairperson Carole Brueckner has been with the church, she elicits a laugh with the simple reply, "Forever." Born and raised in Troy Hill, Carole leads weekly tours of the chapel, showing scores of people the history housed there. She acts as the resident expert of the church, able to rattle off the history of hundreds of relics with ease. She speaks in a direct, yet warm and gentle manner, carrying a rosary between her fingers as she tells the story of the chapel and just how that collection of relics grew so large. And the lore of St. Anthony's attracts many. "I can honestly tell you since I've been doing these tours, I have done tours for people from every continent." Carole says. "At one time I used to say, every continent but one, Antarctica. Until a gentleman that was sitting here said, 'you can't say that.'"

While the tours are a big part of St. Anthony's, visitors learn quickly this is no museum. Many volunteers and caretakers such as Carole are lifelong members of the parish. They hold

the chapel in a special place not simply because of its unique history, but from the memories they have growing up there. One volunteer, Tom, has been with the church since 1957, when he started altar service.

Another, Mary, recounts her early years when she and all the other schoolchildren would gather for morning mass. "The kneelers were made of wood, and they were so hard. The angle on them was wrong!" She also recalls how "dark and dingy" the chapel was, a hint to the state of disrepair the church fell into at one point. Mary kindly adds, "It's not a museum, it's an open chapel. They have mass here, people get married here." Many people touring share this reverence, remarking about the beauty the chapel holds.

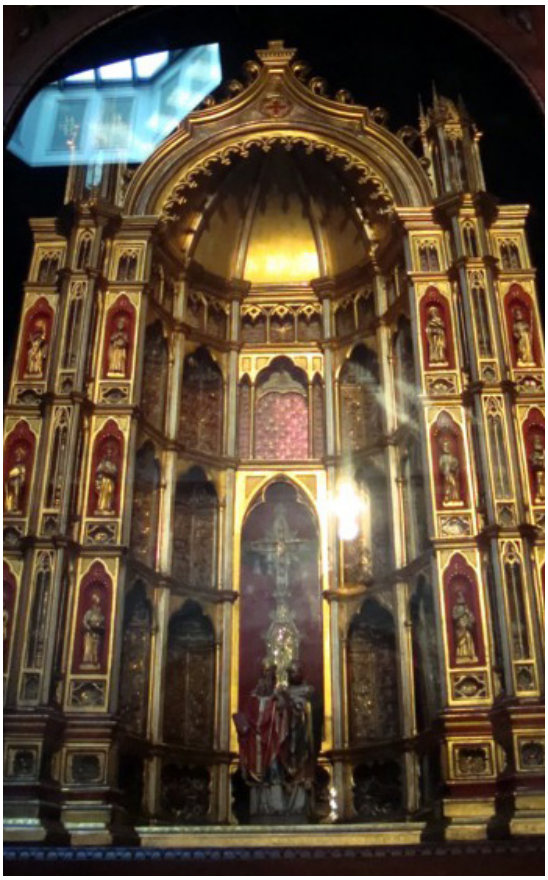
That beauty and awe can be traced back to the passions of its founder – Father Suitbert Godfrey Mollinger. Carole begins her history of St. Anthony's with his story, and she paints him as a larger than life figure. Born in what was then Holland in 1828, she describes Father Mollinger as a healer in many senses of the word. When he was just 16, Father Mollinger decided to pursue medicine. He travelled and studied in Napels, Rome, and Genoa. Around the time he turned 24, Mollinger found another calling though, this time to the religious life. He found his way to the city of Ghent in Belgium, where he joined the seminary. Carole states that at this point his legend began to grow. Father Mollinger addressed spiritual needs when he administered sacraments and hosted religious services. If a member within a household had fallen ill, he would also take care of their physical needs. Towards his 30's, Mollinger took an opportunity to relocate to the United States, where he was eventually appointed to be the first pastor of Most Holy Name Parish in Troy Hill. Standing at the front of the church that means so much to her, Carole states, "and this is, where Father Suitbert Mollinger, began to be known as a priest, a physician, and a healer."

"Father Mollinger had a somewhat unusual hobby, in which he liked to acquire relics of the Saints," Carole explains. The political turmoil in Europe of the mid 1800's afforded Mollinger the opportunity to collect many of them. Many in Italy and Germany sought out Mollinger to hold their relics until their countries were stable again. Carole says that "anyone that knew Father knew of his hobby," and that "Father always responded yes," to these requests. Carole relates that Mollinger decided to rescue more and more of these holy relics, as he sent agents all over to Europe to collect them.

Carole uses an analogy to explain how faith is tied to these treasured relics. "Let's say someone in your family has passed, and you want to remember that person. You have photographs, you have things of them that you can remember them by. Going back to the beginning of our faith, people did not have the monetary means, let alone anything else." Grieving families would usually have only one option. "They actually cherished the bodily remains of people," Carole says as she leads her tour to another glass case. There, patrons get a perfect example of what Carole means, as they find themselves up close to a human skull covered in a light cloth, adorned with jewels in a gold housing.

That skull is attributed to St. Theodore, and is just one of hundreds of stunning relics housed in St. Anthony's. Carole and the parishioners organize these relics into three classes. "A third class relic is usually just a piece of cloth or material that had been touched to the remains of a Saint's body," she explains. She points to a golden reliquary with an ornate cross in the center,

which she explains holds 700 of these small relics. Each piece, no matter how small, has a history. Carole classifies a second class relic as a personal possession, an example being a piece of the veil from the Blessed Mother Mary. And a first class relic is any particle of the Saint's body that may remain. "Hair, teeth, bone, tissue, blood." Carole lists. She also mentions that "anything that came in contact with our Lord is a first class relic."



After Carole gives the history of Father Mollinger, she begins her tour by gathering a group around a picture frame near the front of the church. A red velvet interior houses a dozen or so small emblems. To bring out the details of each, Carole produces a small flashlight to focus patrons' attention. She illuminates the emblem at the top of the frame and to where the second class relic of the Blessed Mother Mary's veil rests. She then lowers the flashlight slightly and states that the relic adjacent belonged to the Holy Sepulcher, the Tomb Jesus was kept in. After each patron gets a good look, she moves back towards the altar, standing near the golden reliquary. The shrine stands a few feet tall, two columns flanking a raised dome resembling a basilica. The columns house 12 small statues, one for each apostle, and of course, each with an accompanying relic. The cross in the middle houses relics of Jesus – a piece from his manger, a splinter from his flagellation column, and thorns from the Crown of Thorns. Carole points to a picture frame below this reliquary. There sits a certificate of authenticity as large as the reliquary itself, affixed with a red wax seal at the bottom. She says, "It does name all 700 Saints whose relics are encased in the golden reliquary."

That reliquary most likely meant much to Father Mollinger as well. Carole instructs the audience to take a good look at its design, then tells them to look upwards towards the ceiling of the church. The columns and domed steeple are immediately recognizable between the two. Local craftsmen from Troy Hill replicated the golden reliquary when designing the backdrop behind the altar, and just like its smaller companion, the structure houses dozens of brass reliquaries encased behind a sheet of glass.

It's just one of the small touches Father Mollinger desired as he planned the construction of the church. Carole explains that as Mollinger's collection of relics grew, "he felt the relics needed to be in a more 'proper' environment." Mollinger petitioned to raise funds for a grand church, but the poor German immigrant families of Troy Hill had little money to contribute. "But Father Suitbert Mollinger was a very determined person," Carole says. He decided to fund and create his own chapel.

The original chapel was a mere 30 feet by 30 feet and had no room for the awe inspiring, life sized wood carvings of the stations of the cross. The anatomically correct statues sat in their crates until Mollinger collected the funds to extend the chapel. The process would be finished 12 years later, in 1892.

The day of the dedication for this extension, Father Mollinger was not well. He was able to make it through the dedication ceremony, but his condition grew worse. Many anticipated seeing him, as Carole recalls newspapers reporting that thousands had flocked to the chapel that

day. Mollinger would sadly pass away just two days later, entrusting St. Anthony's Chapel to the congregation of Most Holy Name church.

"We became the caretakers of St. Anthony's Chapel." Carole explains. The church is technically privately owned and is without an official congregation. It's only means of monetary support comes from donations, with little aid coming from the diocese of Pittsburgh. The chapel's collection of history attracted scores of people, but the loss of Mollinger meant a drop of publicity for the little chapel. Parishioners refrained from advertising and refused to make their chapel a tourist gimmick. Decades later, these residents of Troy Hill would be faced with the prospect of losing the gifts that Mollinger had entrusted to them.

In the mid 1970's, the city of Pittsburgh had fallen on hard times, and the economic downturn wasn't limited to its steel industry. The parishioners of St. Anthony's faced major concerns with the chapel. "For many years, the chapel did fall into much needed repair, and I can tell you that is true because I've lived here all my life." Carole says. "Plaster was coming down. It was in deplorable means." Renovations were much needed, but Troy Hill residents were hit hard by Pittsburgh's downturn. The situation became dire as the bishop of the dioceses considered tearing the building down. "Needless to say, this upset many people." Carole recalls.

The parishioners needed to organize, and they presented the bishop with a plan. They decided to split the renovations into three parts. They would have to secure funds for the first step before considering the second, and likewise for the third. First, the roof was completely replaced, with a skylight installed to allow natural light to come in. To protect the relics, UV shielding was utilized so that sunlight couldn't do any damage to the sensitive paintings and reliquaries. After that, the parishioners again banded together to raise funds for the next phase – cleaning the exterior of the building. For anyone who knows the history of steel manufacturing in Pittsburgh, this meant removing the trademark layer of black soot that covered the outside of the building. With the pollution gone, the church's long hidden walls were revealed. "Big change in the neighborhood" Carole recalls with a smirk, saying it was a night and day difference. Finally, the interior was renovated, a difficult task since contractors would have to work carefully around all the precious relics encased behind plate glass. The parishioners saw to it that each phase was completed, and St. Anthony's was secured.

Carole leads her tour group back towards the altar. In between cataloging another series of relics, she explains, "If I'm talking quickly it's because I want to get in as much as possible." She directs her flashlight under the altar to a small compartment. Slightly obscured by the altar cloth, a golden sarcophagus is illuminated. Carole explains that there rests the full skeletal remains of St. Demetrius, the bones wrapped in silk and ornamented with even more jewels. It's another piece of incredible history that thankfully remains preserved for the many visitors of St. Anthony's.

With such a collection, it's a wonder that many Pittsburghers still haven't even heard of St. Anthony's. The parishioners do little promotion, instead allowing those with a natural interest to discover the collection of history on their own terms. Carole has her own take. "If you don't mind me saying, you're brought here when St. Anthony brings you here, when you're ready. Think of sometimes when you've experienced things in life that you forget, and you say 'I wish I was more open and would've paid more attention.'" For many visitors of St. Anthony's, when the time comes and they make the journey to the church, it is an experience they will never forget. ■